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"The Blessed Damsel" is perhaps the best known poem by [Dante Gabriel Rossetti](#), as well as the title of his painting (and its replica) illustrating the subject. The poem was first published in 1850 in the [Pre-Raphaelite](#) journal *[The Germ](#)*. Rossetti subsequently revised the poem twice and republished it in 1856, 1870 and 1873.^[1] The poem has 24 stanzas of 6 lines each, totalling 144 lines.

The Blessed Damozel



The painting is divided into two horizontal sections. The upper section shows a woman, the Blessed Damozel, with long brown hair adorned with red and white flowers. She wears a blue robe with a white ermine-trimmed collar and a white sash. She is seated, holding a golden book and a white lily. Below her, three figures look up at her: a man with a beard and a crown, a woman with a crown, and a child. The lower section shows a man in a dark, patterned robe lying on a bed, looking up at the woman. The background is dark and filled with many small, faint figures of people.

Artist	Dante Gabriel Rossetti
Year	1875–1878
Medium	oil on canvas
Dimensions	174 cm × 94 cm (69 in × 37 in)
Location	Lady Lever Art Gallery, Port Sunlight, England

Poem [[edit](#)]

The poem was partially inspired by [Edgar Allan Poe's poem "The Raven"](#),^[2] with its depiction of a lover grieving on Earth over the death of his loved one. Rossetti chose to represent the situation in reverse. The poem describes the [damozel](#) observing her lover from heaven, and her unfulfilled yearning for their reunion in heaven. The first four stanzas of the poem are inscribed on the frame of the painting:

The blessed damozel	Herseemed she scarce
leaned out	had been a day
From the gold bar of	One of God's
Heaven;	choristers;
Her eyes were	The wonder was not
deeper than the	yet quite gone
depth	From that still look of
Of waters stilled at	hers;
even;	Albeit, to them she left,
She had three lilies in	her day
her hand,	Had counted as ten
And the stars in her	years.
hair were seven.	(To one, it is twenty
	of years.
Her robe, ungirt	of years.
from clasp to hem,	... Yet now, and in this
No wrought flowers	place,
did adorn,	Surely she leaned o'er
But a white rose of	me—her hair
Mary's gift,	Fell all about my face. .
For service meetly	..
worn;	Nothing: the autumn
Her hair that lay	fall of leaves.
along her back	The whole year sets
Was yellow like ripe	apace.) ^[1]
corn.	

Paintings [\[edit \]](#)

The Blessed Damsel is the only one of Rossetti's paired pictures and poems in which the poem was completed first. Friends and patrons repeatedly urged Rossetti to illustrate his most famous poem,^[3] and he finally accepted a commission from William Graham in February 1871. After the work was completed Graham requested a [predella](#), the lower part of the painting, on December 31, 1877. His total cost

was £1157. [Alexa Wilding](#) modelled the damozel in Paradise, Wilfred John Hawtrey modelled the child–angel, and the probable model for the left–hand angel was [May Morris](#).



Replica by Rossetti, 1879, sold to Frederick Leyland. Now at the [Lady Lever Art Gallery](#).

Another, later version is in the Lady Lever Art Gallery. Frederick Richards Leyland

commissioned eighteen paintings from Rossetti, not counting unfulfilled commissions. Soon after Leyland acquired his first Rossetti painting, he and Rossetti explored which was eventually formed with of *The Blessed Damsel* painted *Proserpine*.^[5] Three additional Rossetti in Leyland's drawing room, all of "stunners."^[4]

Six Rossetti paintings as hung in Leyland's drawing room, 1892. *The Blessed Damsel* hangs third from the left.^[4] (Click on any painting for its article.)

Music [\[edit \]](#)

Several pieces of music were based on the poem, including those for orchestra by [Debussy](#), [Granville Bantock](#) (1891), [Edgar Bainton](#) (1907), [Ernest Farrar](#) (1907); for piano by [Arnold Bax](#) (1906); for string quartet by [Benjamin Burrows](#) (1927); and a 1928 choral by [Julius Harrison](#).

The poem was the inspiration for Claude Debussy's *La Damoiselle élue* (1888), a cantata for two soloists, female choir, and orchestra

A 2007 popular song of the same name by [Tangerine Dream](#) appears on their album *Madcap's Flaming Duty*.

See also [\[edit \]](#)

- List of paintings by Dante Gabriel Rossetti
- Elsie Whitaker Martinez

Notes [\[edit\]](#)

1. ^ [a](#) [b](#) McGann, Jerome, ed. (2005). "The Blessed Damsel (with predella), Dante Gabriel Rossetti, 1875-8" [↗](#). *Rossetti Archive*. Institute for Advanced Technology in the Humanities, University of Virginia. Retrieved 16 February 2012.
2. ^ "The Painterly Image in Poetry [↗](#)." *The Norton Anthology of English Literature: The Victorian Age*. 2009. Norton and Company. 3 Jun 2009.
3. ^ Treuherz et al. (2003), p. 100
4. ^ [a](#) [b](#) *Waking Dreams*, p. 26 (figure 5).
5. ^ *Waking Dreams*, p. 24

Sources [\[edit \]](#)

- Treuherz, Julian; [Prettejohn, Elizabeth](#); Becker, Edwin (2003). [Dante Gabriel Rossetti](#). London New York, N.Y: Thames & Hudson. ISBN 0-500-09316-4.
- Wildman, Stephen; Laurel Bradley; Deborah Cherry; John Christian; David B. Elliott; Betty Elzea; Margaretta Fredrick; Caroline Hannah; Jan Marsh; Gayle Seymour (2004). *Waking Dreams, the Art of the Pre-Raphaelites from the Delaware Art Museum* Art Services International. p. 395

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